

Eye Contact

Forced eye contact is painful, it interferes with processing, and it is not evidence of attention.

Reach for it in the meeting where eye contact is about to be written into a goal.

The Short Version

Forcing eye contact harms Autistic and neurodivergent students.

It is painful for many. It disrupts listening and processing. It triggers anxiety and dissociation. It serves the adult's comfort — not the child's learning.

It should not be forced in school. It should not appear as a goal in IEPs or behavioral plans.

Why Eye Contact Should Not Be Forced in School

Eye contact is often treated as a sign of attention, respect, or honesty in classrooms. Because of this assumption, many students—especially autistic students—are pressured or required to make eye contact.

In some cases, **eye contact is even written into Individualized Education Program (IEP) goals.**

This practice can be harmful.

For many neurodivergent people, eye contact is **physically uncomfortable, cognitively overwhelming, or disruptive to thinking.** Forcing it does not improve learning or communication. Instead, it often increases stress and reduces a student's ability to focus.

Schools should support **engagement and understanding**, not enforce a single cultural style of communication.

Eye Contact Can Be Physically Painful

For many Autistic people, eye contact causes genuine sensory overload.

- Brain imaging research shows eye contact triggers overactivation in a region of the brain that produces arousal and distress in Autistic people.
 - "Forcing children with autism to look into someone's eyes in behavioral therapy may create a lot of anxiety for them." — Nouchine Hadjikhani, Harvard Medical School
 - When a child looks away, they are protecting themselves from pain — not showing disrespect.
 - Demanding eye contact despite this pain is demanding that a child hurt themselves to make adults more comfortable.
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Gaze Aversion Is a Processing Tool — Not a Behavior Problem

Looking away is how many neurodivergent people pay attention.

- Autistic people can often either look or listen — not both at the same time.
 - Gaze aversion reduces incoming sensory information so the brain can process language and meaning.
 - Research shows that even neurotypical adults answer challenging questions better when they look away.
 - Children can be taught to use gaze aversion as a deliberate learning strategy — and perform significantly better as a result.
 - A student looking out the window and then repeating everything the teacher said is paying attention. Insisting they make eye contact may make it impossible for them to do so.
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Eye Contact Goals in IEPs Are Not About the Child

IEP goals that require eye contact are about social performance — not learning, communication, or wellbeing.

- "Eye contact — who's it for? It's not for the Autistic child. It's for the recipient. It's for their own validation." — Thinking Person's Guide to Autism
 - Eye contact goals train Autistic children to perform neurotypical social norms for other people's comfort.
 - These goals do not build communication skills, academic skills, or self-advocacy.
 - They build masking — the exhausting, harmful practice of suppressing authentic ways of being to appear more neurotypical.
 - Masking is linked to burnout, anxiety, depression, and loss of identity.
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The "Look at Me" Demand Causes Real Harm

When eye contact becomes a compliance demand, the costs are significant.

- Children who are forced to make eye contact while it causes pain sometimes dissociate — leaving their bodies to cope with the overwhelm.
 - ABA-style "look at me" protocols — delivered forty hours a week — can strip children of their coping strategies and their sense of self.
 - Power struggles over eye contact frustrate everyone and "thwart the abilities of individuals with autism to respond." — Indiana Institute on Disability and Community
 - The expectation that lack of eye contact signals dishonesty or disinterest is a myth. Forty years of research have debunked any link between gaze and deception.
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The Myth That Eye Contact Signals Attention Is Not Supported by Evidence

Many educators were taught that eye contact shows listening.

But attention and gaze are not the same thing.

This is a neurotypical norm — not a universal truth.

- Eye contact is not evidence of engagement, honesty, or respect.
- Lack of eye contact is not evidence of disinterest, dishonesty, or non-compliance.
- Autistic communities have different but equally valid norms around eye contact.
- Neurotypical norms are not the only norms.

Many neurodivergent people focus better when they are:

- looking away
- staring at a fixed point
- doodling or stimming
- focusing on objects instead of faces

These strategies help regulate cognitive load and support **deep attention**.

Forcing eye contact can interrupt thinking and **reduce comprehension**.

Related concept:

- **Monotropism** (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/library/monotropism/>)
- **Deep Attention** (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/library/deep-attention/>)

Eye Contact Can Cause Sensory Overload

Faces and eyes carry extremely dense social information.

For many autistic people, looking into someone's eyes can produce:

- sensory intensity
- emotional overload
- competing signals
- difficulty processing speech

Trying to maintain eye contact while listening may force the brain to process **too many inputs at once**.

Students may appear disengaged when they look away, but looking away often helps them **reduce sensory load and understand what is being said**.

Related concept:

- [Sensory Load](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/library/sensory-load/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/library/sensory-load/>)
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Eye Contact Can Interfere With Processing Time

Some students need additional time to process spoken language.

Looking away from a speaker can help them:

- concentrate on auditory input
- reduce visual distractions
- organize responses

When eye contact is forced, cognitive resources shift toward **social monitoring instead of comprehension**.

Related concept:

- [Processing Time](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/library/processing-time/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/library/processing-time/>)
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Forced Eye Contact Encourages Masking

When students are trained to perform eye contact despite discomfort, they are often learning to **mask their natural regulation strategies**.

Masking may include:

- suppressing stimming
- forcing facial expressions
- performing social behaviors that feel unnatural

Long-term masking is associated with increased stress, exhaustion, and **autistic burnout**.

Related concept:

- **Masking Pressure** (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/library/masking-pressure/>)
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Communication Styles Are Culturally Diverse

Eye contact norms vary across cultures and communities.

In many cultures, avoiding eye contact with authority figures is considered respectful.

Teaching that eye contact is the “correct” behavior can unintentionally enforce **neuronormative and culturally narrow communication expectations**.

Schools should support **multiple communication styles** rather than enforcing a single one.

What to Do Instead

Change the expectation — not the child.

- Accept that a student looking away or at the floor may be deeply engaged.
- Do not read gaze aversion as rudeness, defiance, or inattention.
- Do not prompt “look at me” as a precursor to instruction.
- Do not include eye contact in IEP goals, behavioral plans, or compliance rubrics.
- If a student chooses to make eye contact, welcome it. If they don’t, welcome that too.
- Focus IEP goals on communication, learning, and self-determination — not on performing neurotypical body language.
- Presume competence. The child who is not looking at you is very likely paying close attention.

Instead of eye contact, educators can look for signs of engagement such as:

- responding to questions
- participating in discussion
- demonstrating understanding
- asking questions
- completing work

A student may be **fully engaged while looking away**.

Engagement should be measured by **learning and participation**, not by gaze direction.

"We can either look like we're paying attention, or we can actually pay attention, in our way, using our tools."

— Ryan Boren, Stimpunks Foundation

Better Design for Neurodivergent Classrooms

Instead of requiring eye contact, classrooms can support diverse communication styles by:

- allowing students to look away while listening
- permitting movement and stimming
- reducing sensory overload
- supporting processing time
- offering multiple participation options

These practices support **attention, regulation, and learning for all students**.

Related design guidance:

- [Designing a Neurodivergent Classroom](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/neurodivergent-classroom/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/neurodivergent-classroom/>)
 - [Designing Flexible Participation](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/flexible-participation/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/flexible-participation/>)
 - [Designing Predictable Environments](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/predictable-environments/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/predictable-environments/>)
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The Principle

Students should not be required to perform behaviors that interfere with their ability to learn.

For many neurodivergent students, **looking away is a tool for thinking.**

Supporting that difference is not lowering expectations.

It is **designing environments that respect how diverse minds work.**

Further Reading

- Eye Contact — Stimpunks Glossary (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/eye-contact/>)
 - Should We Insist on Eye Contact with People who have Autism Spectrum Disorders — Indiana Institute on Disability and Community (<https://www.iidc.indiana.edu/?pageId=472>)
 - Autism and Eye Contact — Judy Endow, MSW (<http://ollibean.com/autism-and-eye-contact/>)
 - Eye Contact: For The Recipient's Validation Only — Thinking Person's Guide to Autism (<http://www.thinkingautismguide.com/2017/05/eye-contact-for-recipients-validation.html>)
 - Study: Overstimulation, not indifference, makes eye contact hard for people with autism — Philadelphia Inquirer (www.philly.com/philly/)
 - Helping children think: Gaze aversion and teaching — British Journal of Developmental Psychology (<http://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1348/026151005X49872/abstract>)
 - Behaviorism — Stimpunks Why Sheet (<https://stimpunks.org/why/behaviorism/>)
 - The Cult of Compliance and the Policing of the Norm — Stimpunks (<https://stimpunks.org/policing/>)
 - Masking — Stimpunks Glossary (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/masking/>)
 - Burnout — Stimpunks (<https://stimpunks.org/burnout/>)
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Where this sheet comes from. It is written and revised as Markdown in the open: Eye Contact.md. That file is the source this page and its PDF are both generated from, so the three cannot say different things.

This sheet is also published as a page on stimpunks.org.

There is a one-sheet broadside of this argument — the version you pin up.